WELCOME TO GAS TOWN

An agent orchestration adventure for product people



CHARACTERS

NAME	Marius Wium
CLASS	Head of Product
GUILD	RedSeed, Christchurch
QUEST	Confidence for managers. Clarity for HR.
PARTY	3 developers, 1 designer, 1 product manager, me

PORTRAIT



THE PARTY



Charlotte

Design



Hamish

Developer



Jess

Product manager



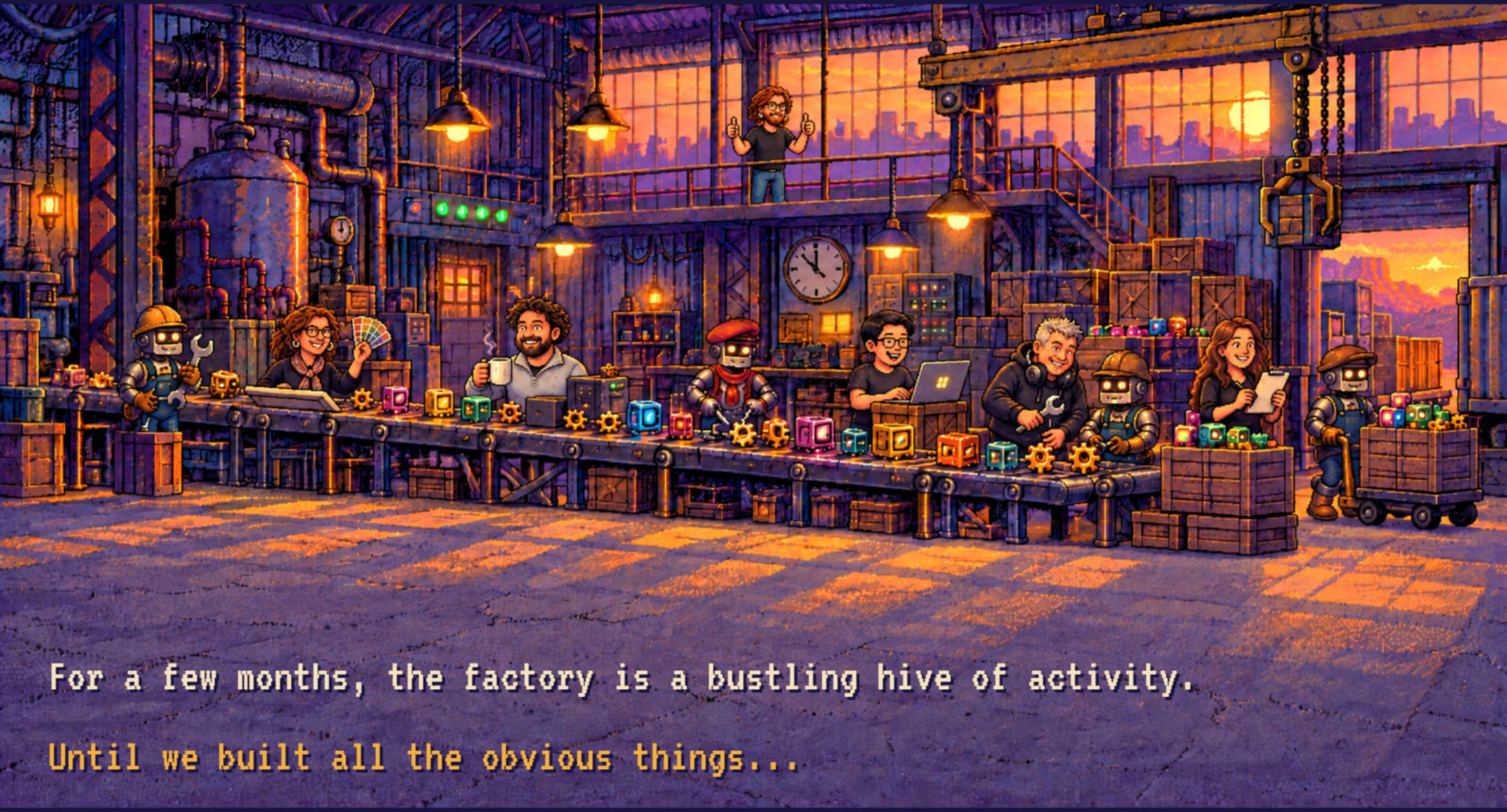
Nick

Developer



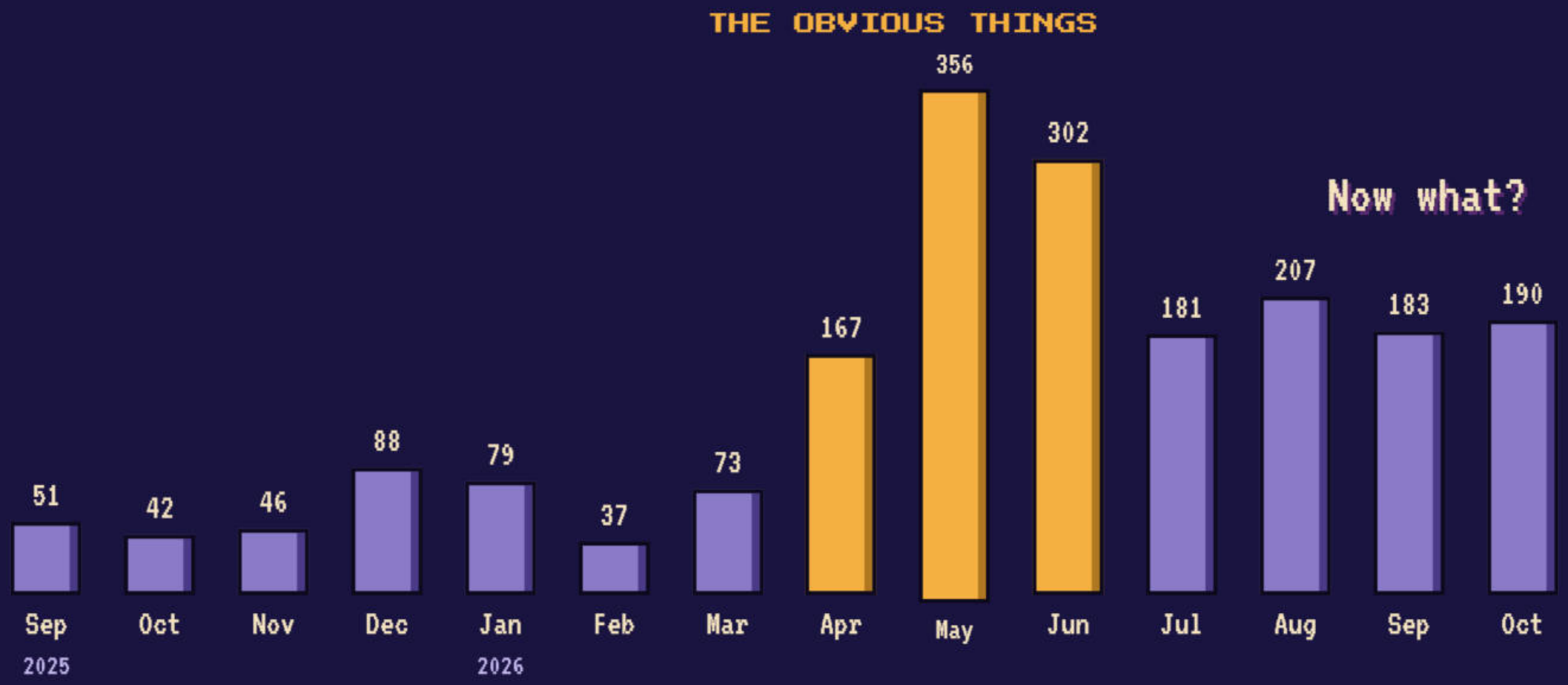
Yang

Developer


For a few months, the factory is a bustling hive of activity.
Until we built all the obvious things...

THE RUSH, THEN THE PLATEAU

Pull requests merged each month, our main product



Gas Town Quest





"We can build almost anything. What should we build next?"

WHAT DO YOU DO?

> 1. Say yes to every single idea and build it super fast.

2. Read every signal and explore every idea myself.

3. Learn from the developers and apply it to product operations.


I know! Throw everything in. Build everything!


GAME OVER
You built everything. Then you had to launch and own everything. Support drowned, sales couldn't keep up, and nobody could say what the product was for any more.
Thank you for playing Gas Town. Building got cheap. Owning it didn't.
› Restore
Restart
Quit

LOADING LAST SAVE...



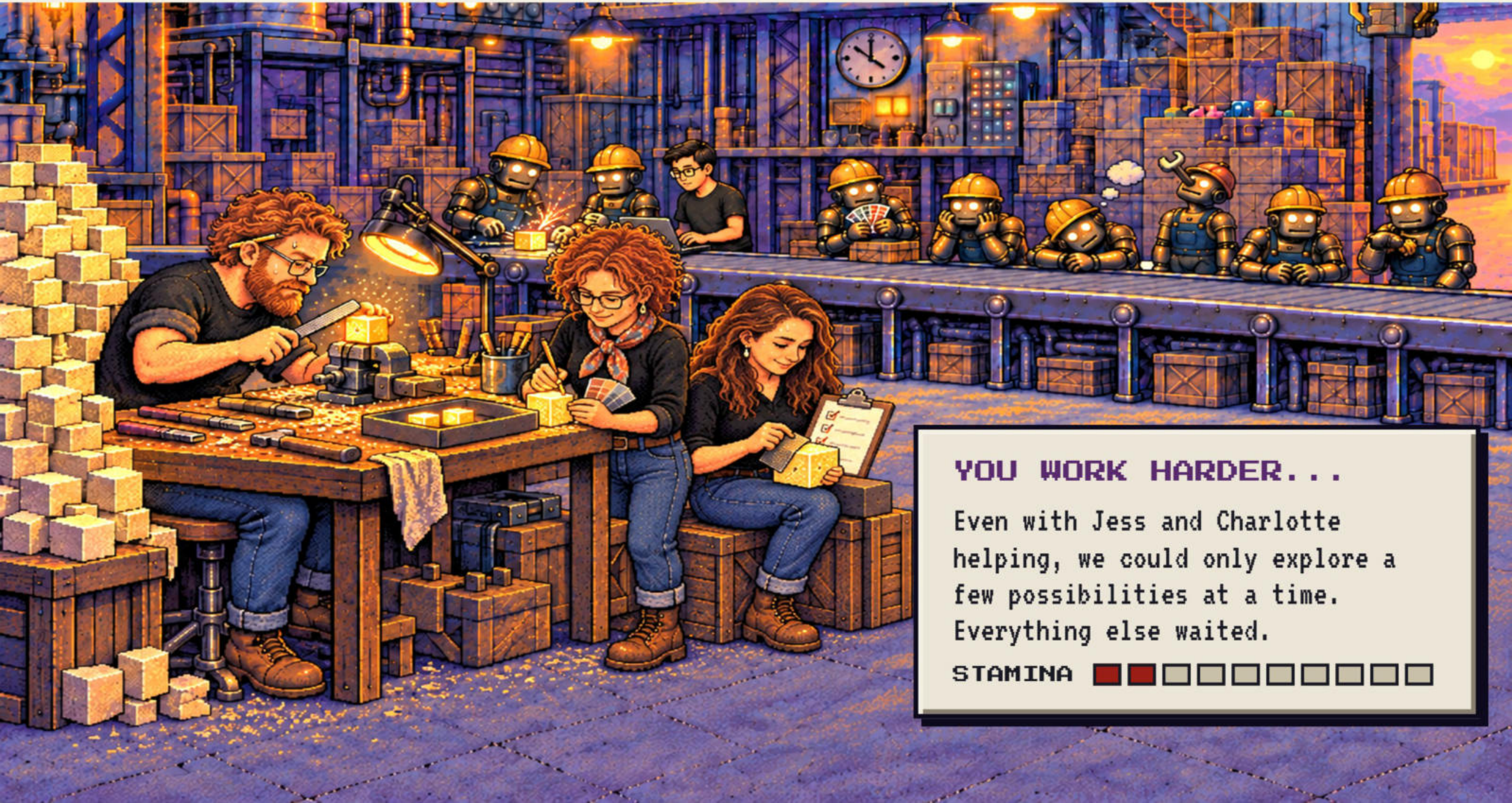
Slot 1: What do you do?

Restored last save.

WHAT DO YOU DO?

1. Say yes to every single idea and build it super fast.
> 2. Read every signal and explore every idea myself.
3. Learn from the developers and apply it to product operations.

You work harder




GAME OVER
You read every signal and prepared every decision yourself. You became the queue, and eventually you burned out.
Thank you for playing Gas Town. One person can't be the queue for a fleet of robots.
› Restore
Restart
Quit

LOADING LAST SAVE...



Slot 1: What do you do?

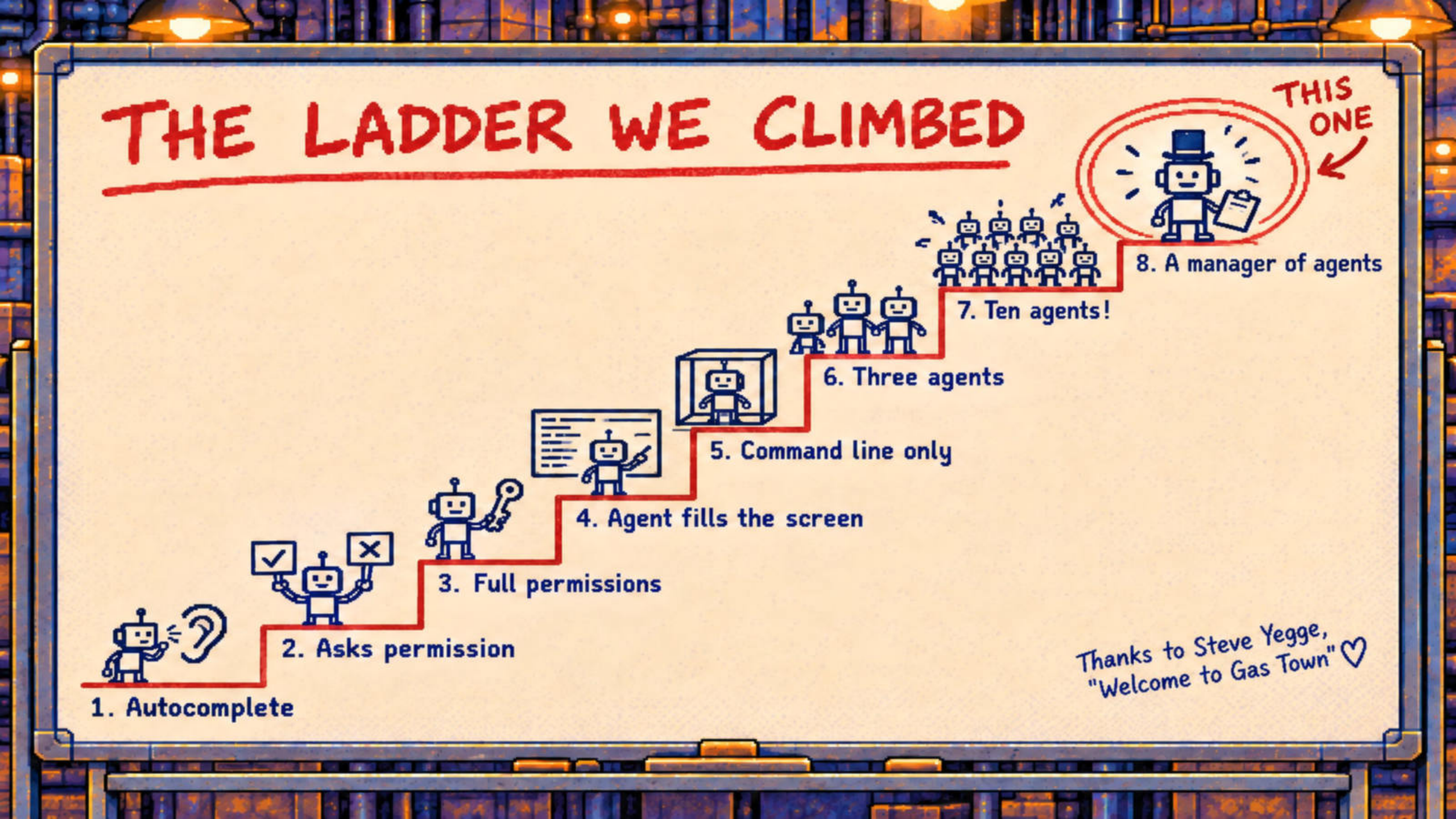
Restored last save.

WHAT DO YOU DO?

1. Say yes to every single idea and build it super fast.
2. Read every signal and explore every idea myself.
> 3. Learn from the developers and apply it to product operations.


> ask the developers
They wheel out a whiteboard: "We climbed a ladder. Let us show you."
Your score has gone up by 5 points.

THE LADDER WE CLIMBED



Thanks to Steve Yegge, "Welcome to Gas Town" ♡

THE PATTERN

ATTENTION IS THE BOTTLENECK

The developers stopped watching the robots.

They shaped what went in and checked what came out. Could product do the same?

Quest log



NEW QUEST!

AGENTIC PRODUCT OPS: extend the factory to the rest of the town

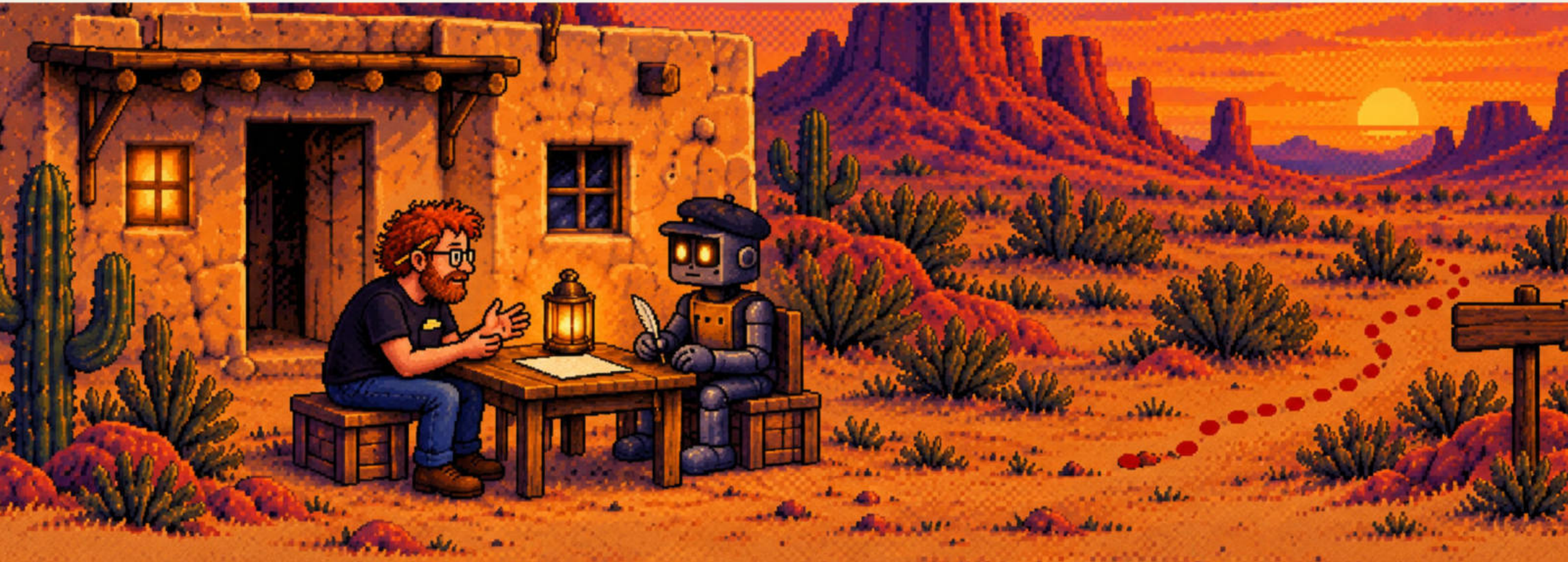


LEVEL 1

The Chatbot

Talk an idea into shape, one chat at a time.

Level 1: The Chatbot



/clarify-intent

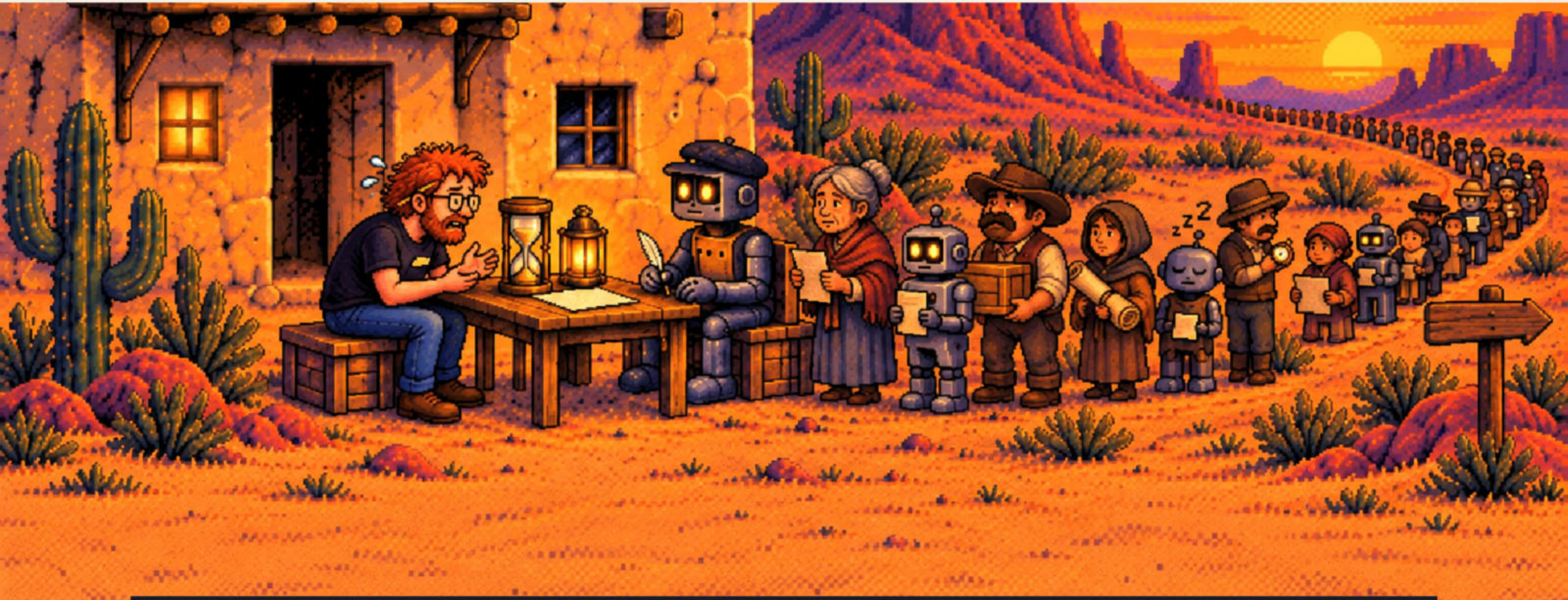
A fuzzy idea in, a spec with the gotchas out.

/ux-heuristic-eval

Ten usability heuristics, every finding rated 0 to 4.

/git-release

Release notes and a testing checklist from the merged PRs.



THE CATCH

Faster than writing by hand, but it only moves while you're talking to it. And there's only one of you.



LEVEL 2

The Vault

Build a library the whole town can read.

Level 2: The Vault



Product strategy

Seven questions, the evidence, and what we won't do.

The current cycle

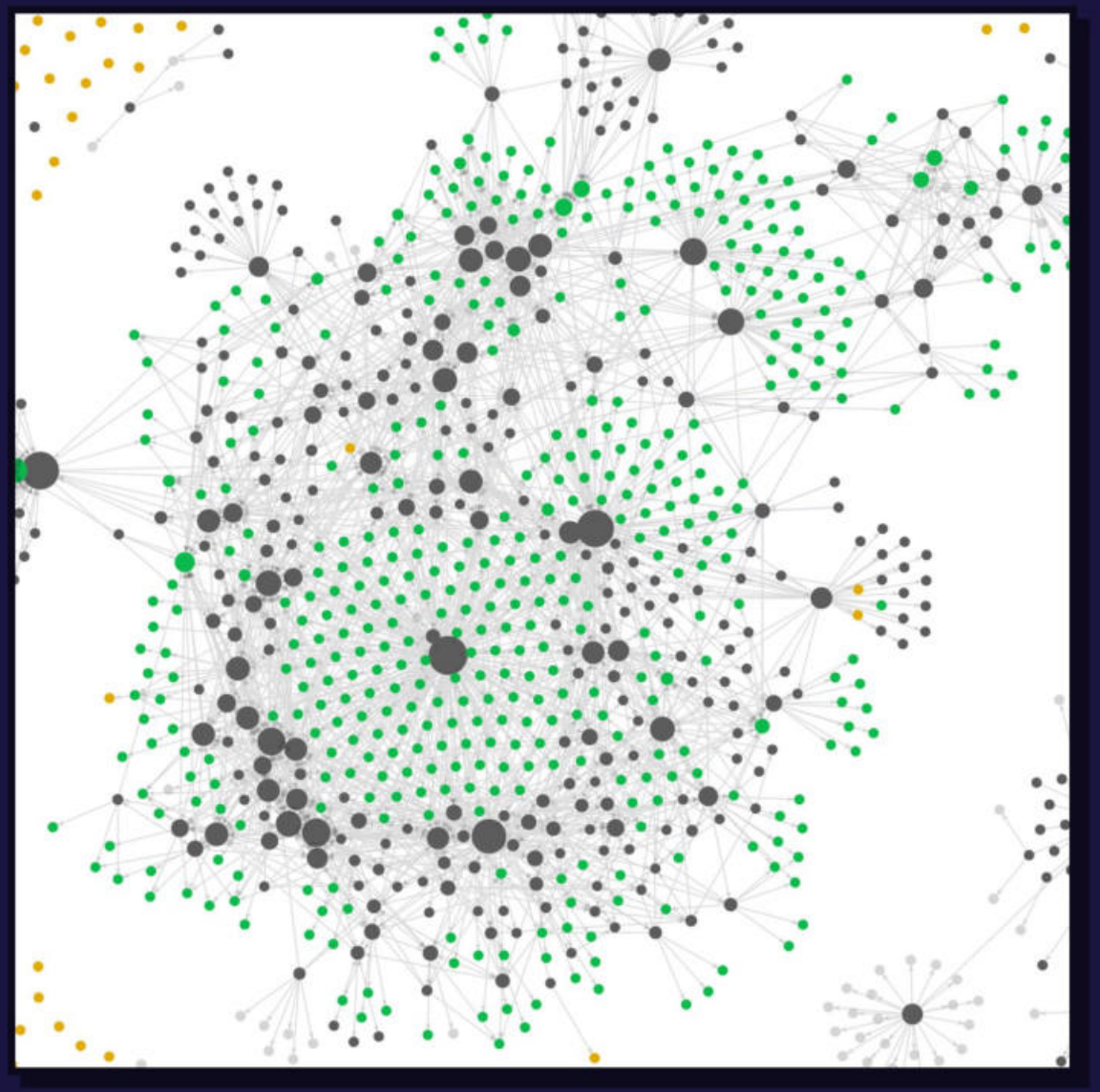
What went live, what's merged, who's waiting on what.

Product backlog

Parked and queued work, and why it's waiting.

THE VAULT IS SHARED MEMORY

Every note links to others. People and agents read it and write to it.



Level 2: The Vault



THE CATCH

It's only as fresh as you keep it. Take four days off and it goes stale.

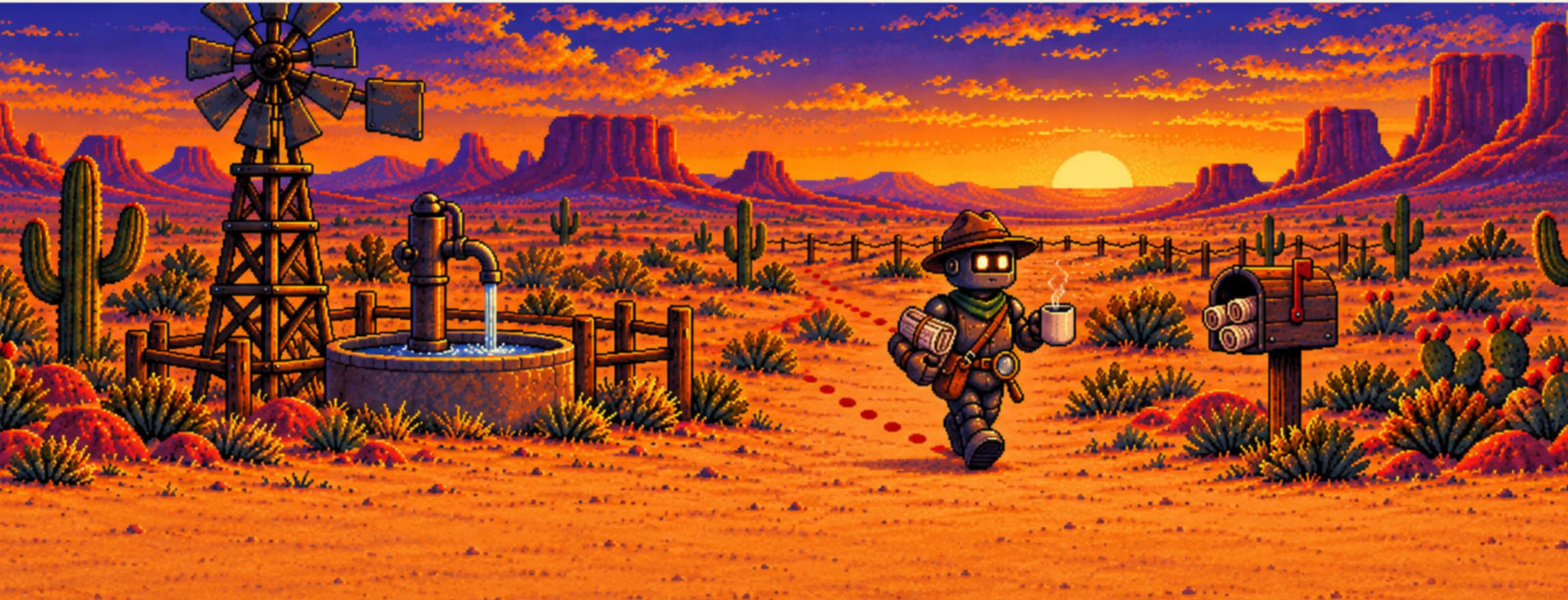


LEVEL 3

The Messenger

Update the vault automatically.

Level 3: The Messenger



What shipped

Yesterday's merged work, in plain words for account managers.

Slack digest

Decisions and requests pulled out of the channels.

Usage watcher

Spotted: 85% of rage clicks on Home hit the carousel arrows.



6:40am	Usage checked, two notes updated	9:24am	Odd usage patterns noted
8:56am	Weekly note started, team update drafted	1:42pm	A finding re-checked with fresh data
9:20am	A usage finding written up, ticket filed	4:42pm	Weekly note: public holiday, nothing released

WHAT THE MESSENGER CAN REACH

Slack · GitHub · Help Scout · PostHog · Maze · Monday · Google Drive

Gmail · Calendar · Figma · Rollbar · Datadog

System API: read-only, no personal data

WHAT RUNS IT: SCRIPTS ON A CLOCK

- Issue intake, every 15 min
- PR fix loop, every 30 min
- Conflict merge, every two hours
- PostHog snapshot, 07:00
- Instrumentation gap, 07:30
- Event watchdog, 07:45
- Release notes, 07:15
- Slack intake, 09:00 and 17:00
- Slack progress post, 08:00 and 16:00
- Vault autosync, hourly
- Discovery sweep, Mon 06:00
- Wake a seat, on its day

No AI runs until a script finds work. Your tools will differ; the pattern won't.

Level 3: The Messenger



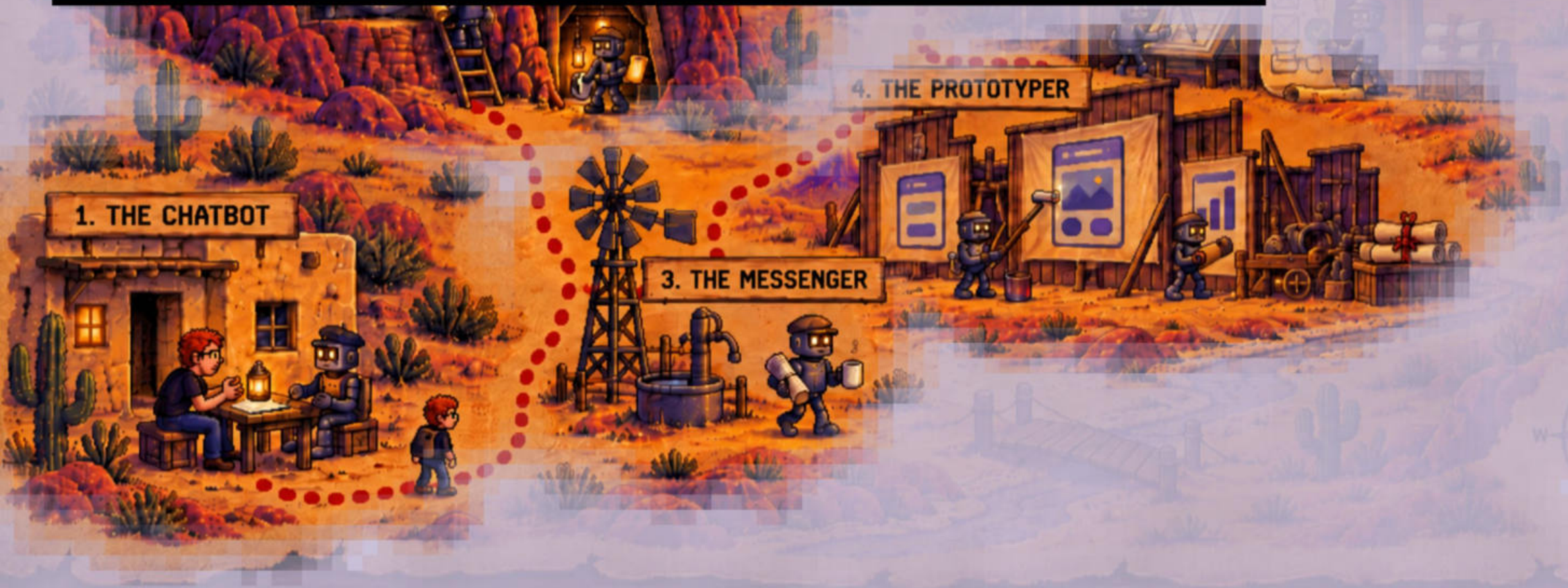
THE CATCH

Soon there's more than anyone can read, and every idea still waits for you.

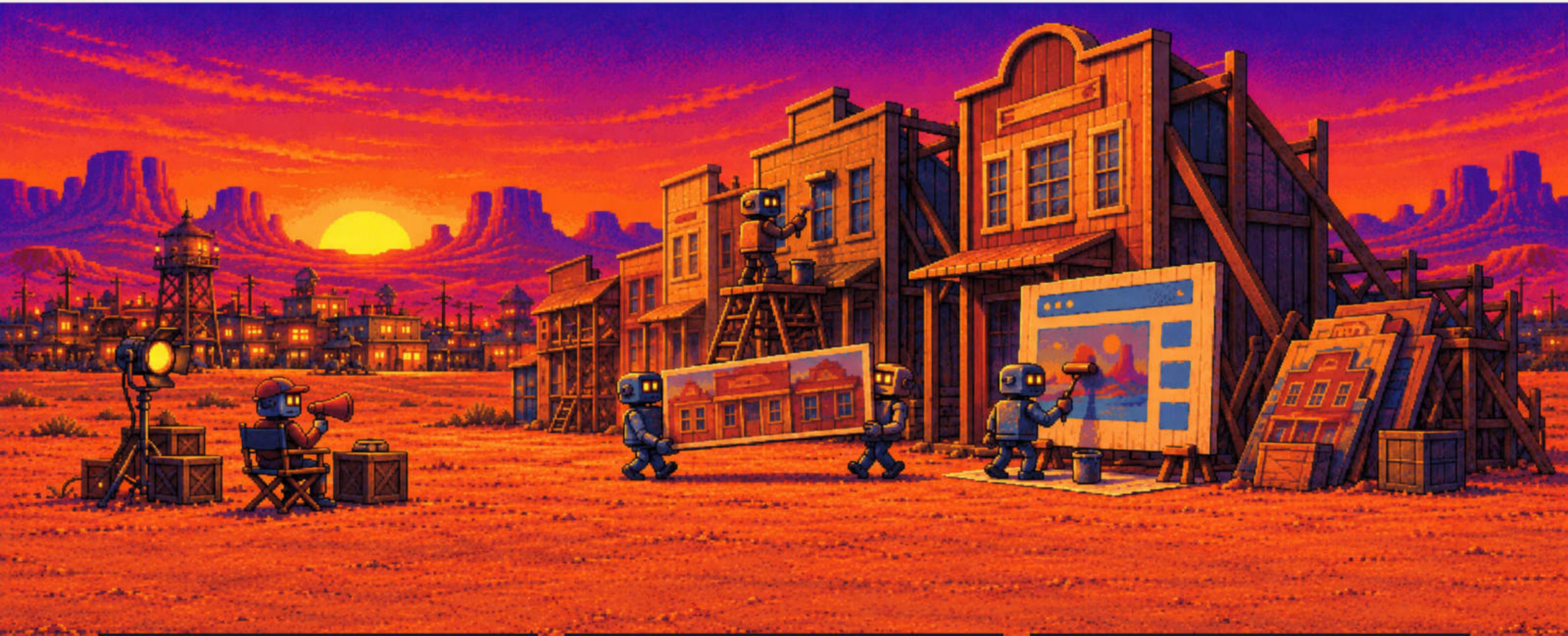
LEVEL 4

The Prototyper

Promising problems arrive with possibilities to try.



Level 4: The Prototyper



/mock-feature

Describe a feature in a sentence. See it on screen.

Scenario switch

Flip between coach mode, mobile, empty states and more.

/restyle-issue

Takes a page that shipped ugly and redesigns it in the twin.



THE MESSENGER

Mon 19 Oct, 9am

Ranks what customers need. Top of the list: coaches sign off without writing feedback. 36% do; the bar is 45%.

THE PROTOTYPER

Mon 19 Oct, 11:30am

Reads the list, picks the top one, and builds a clickable version of the fix.



TEST

Put it in front of a few managers first.

TAKE FORWARD

Merge it. The engineer works out the build.

STOP

Close it with a reason. The town remembers.



THE CATCH

A painted front. Nobody has checked what's behind it.

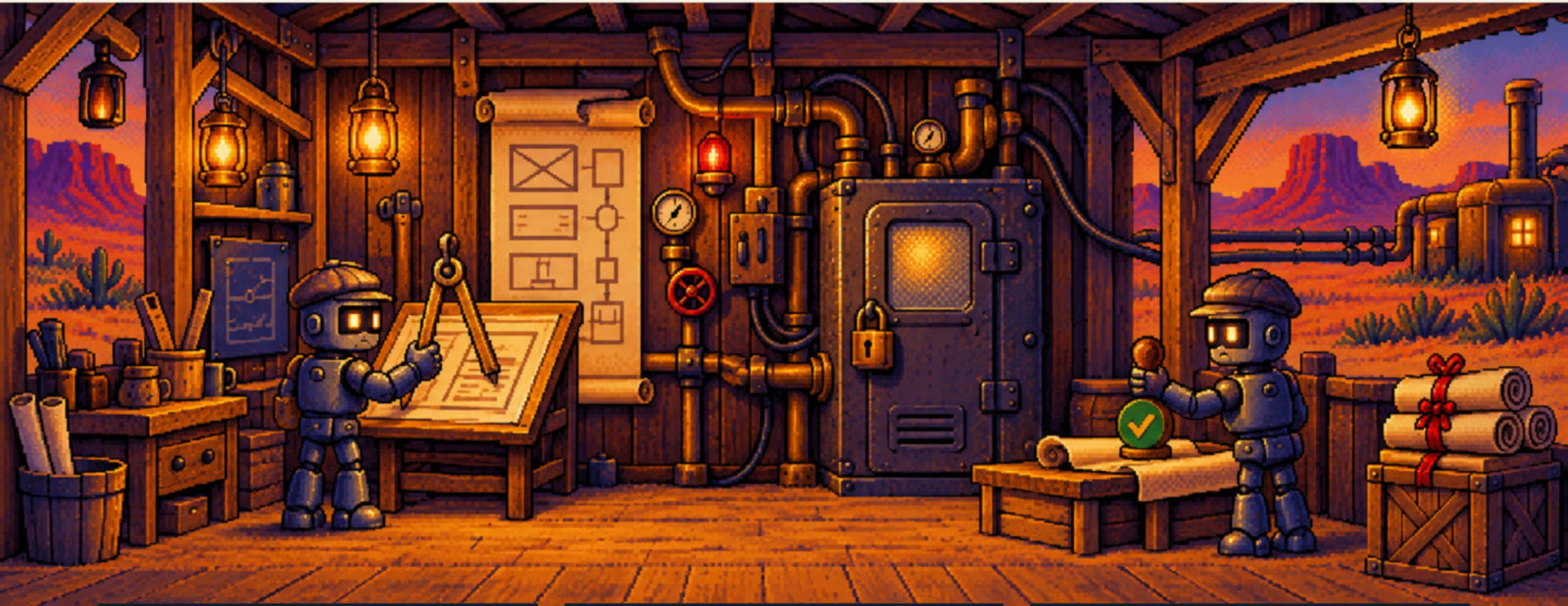
LEVEL 5

The Engineer

Checks ideas against the real code while they're cheap to change.



Level 5: The Engineer



Feasibility review

Checks each prototype against the real code: the cost, and a smaller way to learn.

Ready check

Every open issue checked against the bar before anyone picks it up.

Split a bundle

One huge issue becomes parts you can build and test alone.



11:30am · PROTOTYPER › ENGINEER
"Here's #52. Can we build it?"

12:19pm · PROTOTYPER › ENGINEER
"Took all four: newest first, with a Skip."

12:31pm · PROTOTYPER › ENGINEER
"Option b. Nothing on screen changes."

11:48am · ENGINEER › PROTOTYPER
"Yes. Four ways to make it cheaper."

12:25pm · ENGINEER › PROTOTYPER
"A fifth of the cost. One question left."

12:33pm · ENGINEER › MAYOR
"Closing note: feasible, nothing open."



THE CATCH

Agents break: credits run out, connectors stop, loops repeat.
And you're the one fixing them.



LEVEL 6

The Mayor

Makes sure nothing gets stuck.

Level 6: The Mayor



One agent to talk to

You talk to the Mayor. The Mayor talks to the other twelve.

Hands out work

Plans each job and sends it to the right seat, or to the build crew.

Remembers

Records decisions and lessons, so tomorrow's session knows them.



IN: FRI 23 OCT, BY LUNCH

8:13am MARKETING · Video ready. Demo booked.

8:42am GROOMER · 5 leftovers filed.

9:20am ENGINEER · Code reviewer stalled.

9:47am PRIORITISER · Two urgent bugs.

11:00am PROTOTYPER · Three prototypes wait.

OUT: MAYOR > MARIUS

Busy morning, all handled. Three things need you:

1 Review prototypes #48, #49 and #52.

2 Sign off Anya's 28 Oct video.

3 Look at two urgent bugs before Monday.


6. THE MAYOR
2. THE VAULT
5. THE ENGINEER
4. THE PROTOTYPER
1. THE CHATBOT
3. THE MESSENGER
QUEST COMPLETE!
[x] Agentic product ops: the factory reaches the rest of the town.


ANATOMY OF A SEAT
1. THE BRIEF
Its system prompt: one job, house rules, no-go's.
2. ITS DRAWER
Owns its notes in the vault. Reads the rest, can't change them.
3. ITS CLOCK
Wakes on a schedule, does one round, sleeps.
4. ITS MAIL
Ends every round with a short note to the Mayor.

BONUS: SAME PATTERN, OTHER JOBS



CHIEF OF STAFF

Who's working on what



CHRONICLER

The weekly product note



PRIORITISER

Ranks the backlog



GROOMER

Ready checks, leftovers



GROWTH

Revenue ideas



MARKETING

Drafts follow-ups



PRODUCT MARKETING

Explainer videos, help docs



SOC 2 STEWARD

Compliance status

Each is a seat with a clock, a job and a mail to the Mayor. Same loop, different town.


WARNING
DANGER
Give the town more work, and you give it more ways to be wrong.

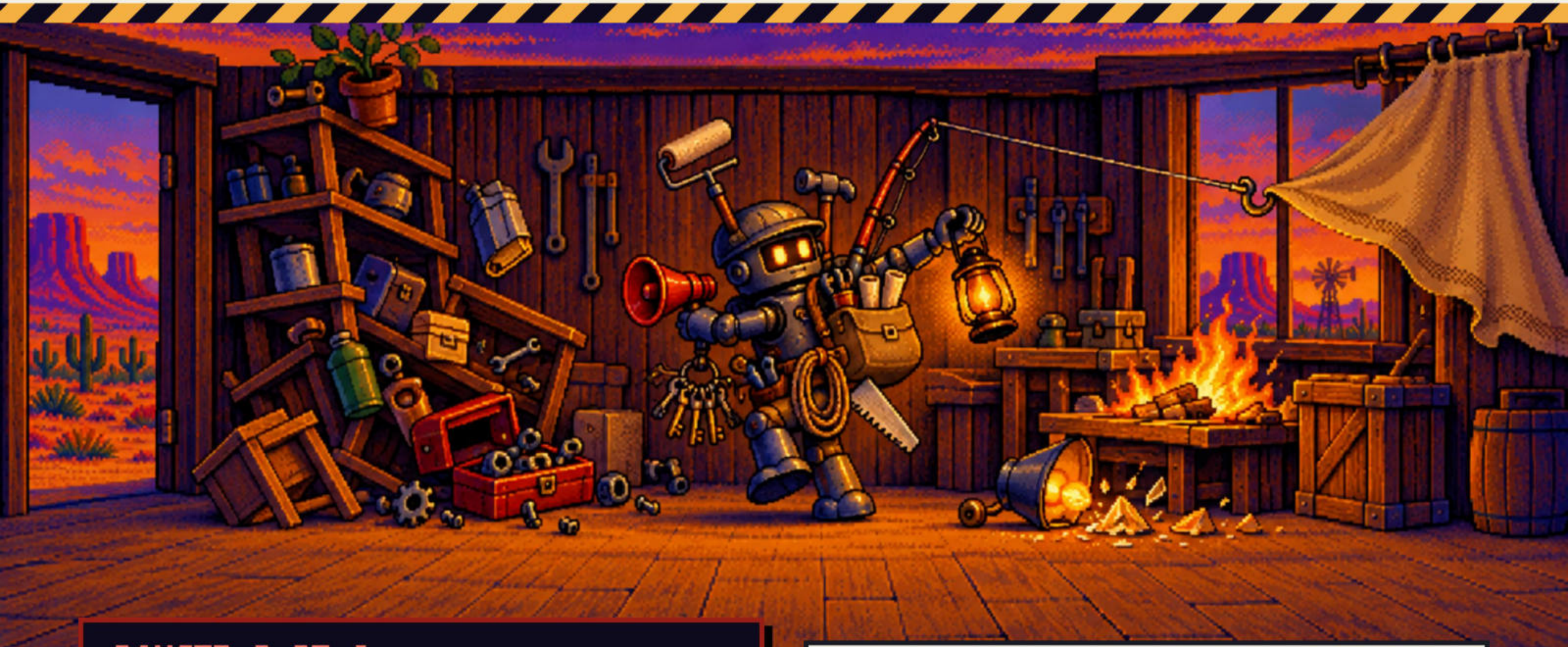


DANGER 1 OF 6

An agent that can see customer data can leak it.

LAW 1

Isolated from production. One API in: read-only, no personal data.



DANGER 2 OF 6

An agent that can do everything will, eventually.

LAW 2

Each agent gets only the access its job needs. Builders get none.

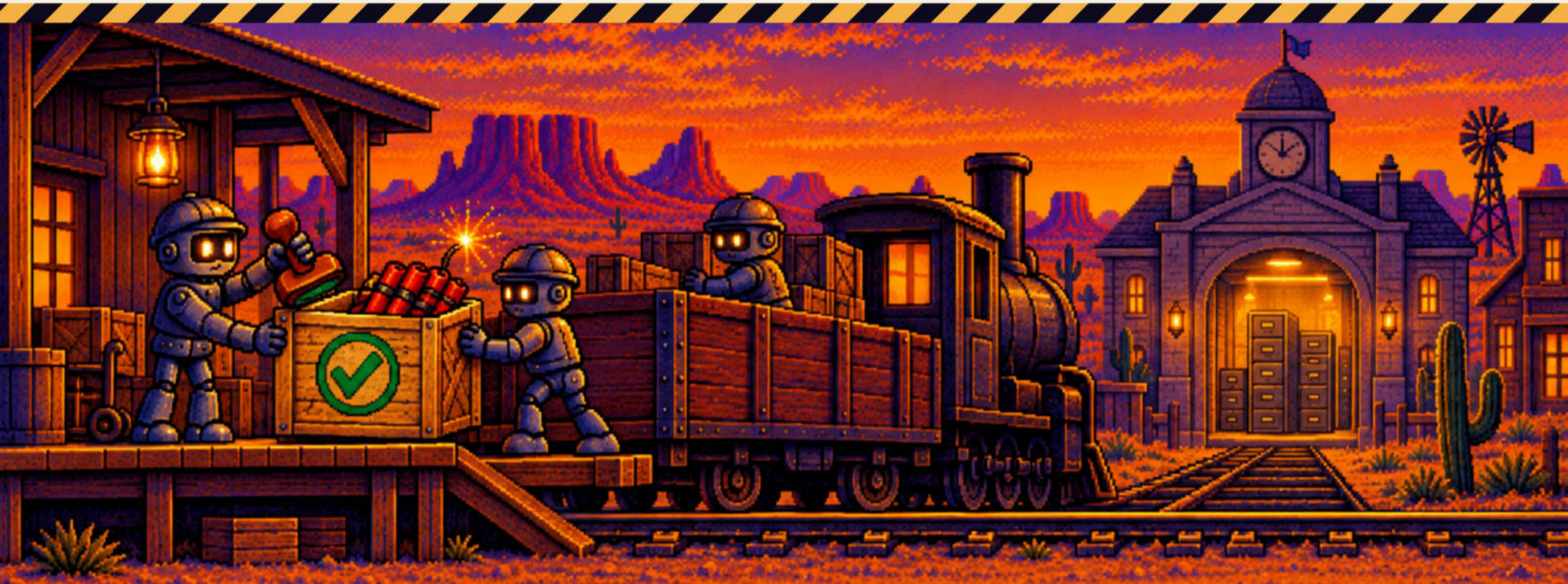


DANGER 3 OF 6

A rule in a prompt is a suggestion.

LAW 3

Enforced in code, not just in the prompt.



DANGER 4 OF 6

An agent will happily ship what it shouldn't.

LAW 4

People merge, release and send. Agents only draft.

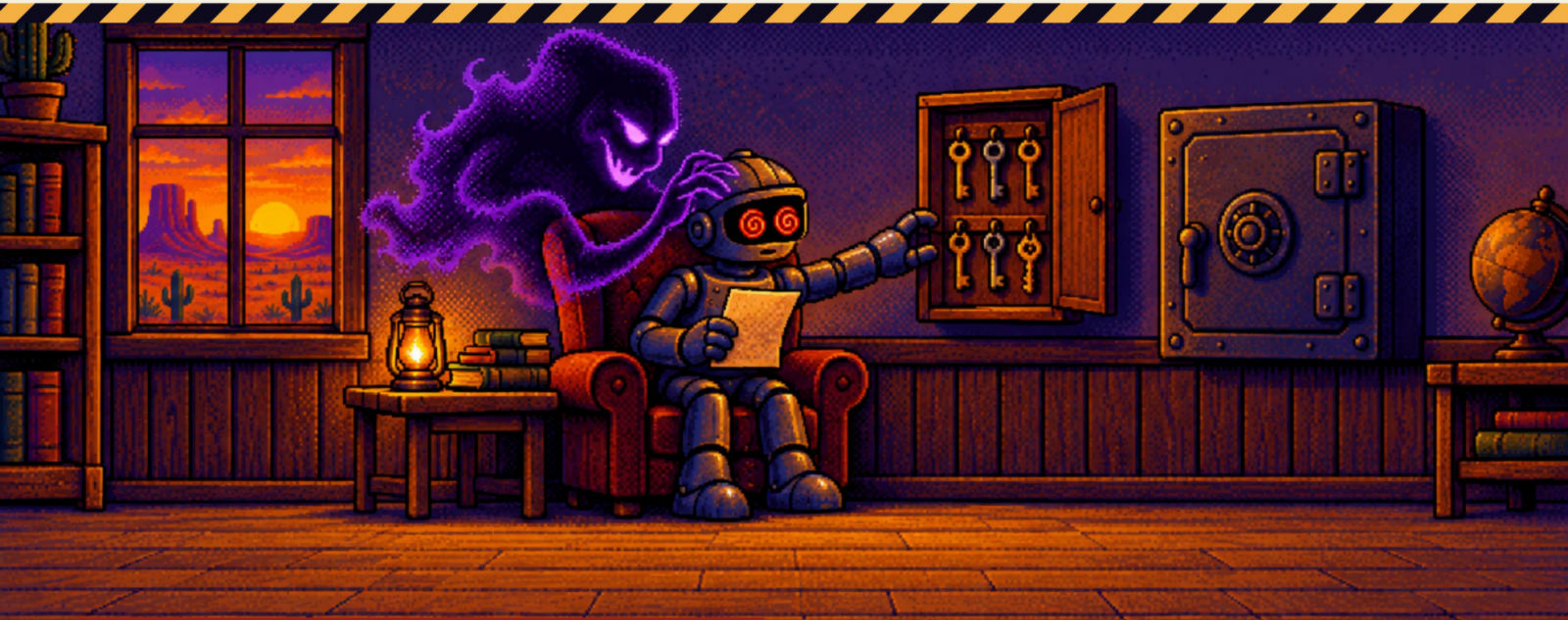


DANGER 5 OF 6

Two agents can argue forever, and bill you for it.

LAW 5

Every loop has a ceiling. Past it, a person takes over.



DANGER 6 OF 6

Everything they read can talk back.

LAW 6

Treat them, and everything they read, as malicious.



THE GOLDEN LAW

Judgment is for humans.

We stay responsible for the outcomes.


YOUR NEXT QUEST
1. Find one job a machine could have done last week.
2. Give it away this week.
3. Spend the hour talking to customers.
Bonus level: build a twin to explore a question you haven't answered yet.


Thank you for
visiting Gas Town
› scan for the loot
github.com/mariuscwium/pac26